

The Business of Visual Effects:
How Public Perception and Unionization Efforts
Influence Working Conditions and Compensation for
Artists
University of York
School of Arts and Creative Technologies
BA (Hons) Business of The Creative Industries
May 2025
Exam Number: Y3912832
Total Word Count: 2,500

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Introduction

Overview

“There are a lot of people working very hard to make sure you don’t see their work, which is counterintuitive, but it’s the nature of what we do. So I will continue to call attention to those visual effects artists, because they work really hard in service to telling the story (Goldman, 2018).”

- Jon Favreau, Pioneering Director of the VFX-Driven The Jungle Book (2016)

The issue with VFX is that, to most, it is a very abstract concept that they do not understand or wish to understand further. And that is normal, that is the goal of VFX: to remain unnoticed and allow the viewer to get lost in the film. When I was younger and was wowed by the VFX in a film (which was not a term I was familiar with at the time), I remember often asking my dad,

“How are they doing that?” And his response would always be something like, “Oh, son, they do all that on the computer.” And that would be the end of it. Which, to his credit, was very much true, but that is only the tip of the iceberg. This also highlights how the general public thinks of VFX; they do not want to think about it. Granted, that is perfectly acceptable, and sometimes even the goal of film directors; to be completely immersed and forget about the technical aspects. However, when it comes to the higher-ups, the people who give orders and control where the money goes, if they too only have a surface-level understanding of the art form or even exert purposeful negligence, they hinder the working conditions, compensation, and unionization efforts of the artists behind them. In turn, this often results in a mediocre final product as well, which negatively impacts the perception of VFX as an art form, at least to those with a deeper love for visuals, the few who notice and appreciate it. In short, there is a disconnect between the vital role VFX artists play and their lack of recognition, sparking my desire to explore this issue further. As the demand for their work grows, VFX and animation artists continue to face significant challenges. This essay will explore how these factors contribute to their undervaluation and propose that strengthening union efforts and advocating for

ethical labor practices is crucial to improving their working conditions and securing fair compensation.

Essay Aim and Scope

With this in mind, although VFX and animation artists are essential to modern filmmaking, they remain critically undervalued due to public underappreciation, industry cost-cutting practices, and weak union representation. This lack of recognition and labor protections has been exacerbated by outsourcing, studio-driven economic pressures, and the rise of AI. However, strengthening union efforts and advocating for ethical labor policies could help secure fair compensation and job stability for these professionals.

To ensure the focus of this paper, three research questions were formulated as guiding principles:

1. To what extent does the public perception of VFX and animation affect the working conditions and compensation of professionals in the U.S. and key outsourced hubs like the UK and India?
 2. Why have unionization efforts for actors (SAG-AFTRA) and writers (WGA) outpaced those for VFX and animation professionals, and what barriers have slowed progress in the latter, as seen with BECTU and IATSE?
 3. How does AI advancement threaten VFX and animation professionals' job security, and can unions like BECTU and IATSE mitigate these risks amid studio pressures?
- Therefore, this dissertation aims to utilize pre-existing literature on the topic; bringing together

external sources such as encyclopedias, academic textbooks, scientifically approved journals, real-world case studies, and reliable online sources but also aims to discuss relevant creative business ethics theory to interpret whether this issue is fundamentally unethical at its core through an academic lens. Alongside secondary sources, primary research is used, aiming to understand and paint a holistic picture of the issue of the unfair conditions of VFX artists, connecting the dots on how their public perception and recognition, industry practices, economic pressures, unionization challenges, technological advancements in AI, all come together to address a present gap in academic literature all while answering the research questions.

Additionally, this essay will focus on the period from 2018 to 2025 to examine key shifts in the visual effects and animation industries. This timeframe captures the rise of generative AI, the increasing spotlight on labor conditions, and the wave of unionization efforts, including the significant strikes by the WGA and SAG-AFTRA in 2023, as well as the push for VFX workers to unionize at major studios like Marvel and Disney. These years represent a crucial turning point in how VFX professionals are treated and valued, making this period essential for understanding the challenges and changes within the industry.

Key Terms and Industry Roles

In today's filmmaking landscape, terms like VFX artists, CGI, and animators often overlap, and the lines between them can blur, especially as digital magic becomes the basis of modern cinema. VFX artists, who enhance or create visuals (typically in live-action), and animators, who focus on crafting movement (usually in fully animated films), both rely on CGI (computer-generated imagery) as a tool to bring their visions to life. They work within similar pipelines, the workflows that stretch from concept to final render, and face the same brutal crunch periods.

For this essay, I'll define VFX (Visual Effects) as digital or practical enhancements to films, whether live-action or animated, and animation as the art of crafting movement for characters or objects. Compositing, a VFX-specific task, blends digital and live-action elements, while CGI powers the fully digital visuals that both roles depend on. Given this closely tied nature, I will use "Visual Effects (VFX) Artists" as an all-encompassing term here, including animators and even motion-capture (mocap) artists, who might seem like performers at first glance but are often seen as technical contributors, overlooked much like traditional pipeline artists like compositors (Cheon & Xu, 2024). To ground this further, the "creative economy" in this context refers to the industry where artistic and technical skills generate cultural and economic value, like film production. Meanwhile, "AI" here means the emerging technologies, generative artificial int

elligence models,
that are reshaping VFX labor, threatening jobs while amplifying studio control.

Methodology

Overview

The aim of this paper is to explore the undervaluation and exploitation of VFX and animation artists within the film industry, focusing on how public perception, industry practices, and unionization efforts impact their working conditions and compensation. The study seeks to understand the complexities surrounding their roles, the barriers to unionization, and the increasing pressures posed by technological advancements, including AI.

Each stage of this research is designed to address these questions and contribute to a holistic understanding of the challenges VFX professionals face today.

The framework for this research will be grounded in industry theory regarding labor relations,

public perception, and technological disruption, with particular focus on VFX artists' roles within film production. Examples of this include; to understand the effects of public perception, theories on labor exploitation and cultural invisibility (Cheon & Xu, 2024) will be used.

Additionally, insights from studies on unionization barriers, such as those involving BECTU and IATSE

(Kerrigan, 2017), will provide context for understanding the challenges of collective bargaining in this sector; to name a few.

This paper will incorporate both secondary and primary research methods. The primary research

will be composed of two key sources: an in-depth interview with a VFX artist to gain first-hand

insights into the realities of working in the industry and a questionnaire distributed to film viewers

to understand how VFX and animation are perceived by the general public. This mixed-method

approach aims to bridge the gap between industry professionals' experiences and audience

perceptions, offering a balanced perspective on the issue at hand.

Essay Structure and Roadmap

In pursuit of a thorough discussion on the ways VFX artists are critically undervalued in the film industry,